

Remembering Pat: Being “Coachable” as a Coach

Joan Cronan

You know, when I think of mentorship, I think of Pat and how she helped others and how others helped her. But one of the things to be mentored or be received mentorship, you have to *want* it and you have to want to keep learning.

One year we were playing in a regional finals and we lost to a team that we never thought we would lose to. I was disappointed. The team was disappointed. I got home before sunrise the next morning my phone rang, and it was Pat Summit. And she said, “Joan, it's my fault. We lost that game.”

I said, “No Pat, it wasn't your fault. They played really well.”

She said, “No, they ran an offense that I didn't understand.”

Now, this is a coach who has won *many* championships. This is a coach that's considered one of the best coaches in the world. And she's saying, “I didn't understand.”

And you know what she said? “I'm going to learn that offense and I'm never going to have somebody beat me with it again.” And she called a male counterpart at that stage, and he came in and spent about a week with us.

You know, Pat had to be willing to admit she was wrong and didn't know something. This is such a winning coach, but she did it. She was willing to listen to other people and keep learning.

And you know what? We never lost to that offense again.